

MOMENTUM

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As a high school junior, Ed Reilly looked forward to attending college, but he feared he might not be as prepared as he needed to be to do well in one of the liberal arts colleges he dreamed of attending.

He wanted to take a college class at the local community college. But in 1996, high school students were not readily admitted to college classes in Kentucky.

Still Reilly persisted. He convinced officials at what was then Paducah Community College to let him take a night class. As a Lyon County High School student, Reilly drove more than 35 miles one way to Paducah to take a college-level English course.

"It was the basic introductory English course," Reilly recently recalled, "but it was still very challenging. I remember writing and writing and writing."

Reilly was one of the first high school honor students at the college. Today, the partnership between West Kentucky Community and Technical College and area high schools is making it possible for more high school students to get both high school and college credit through honor classes and "dual credit agreements."

In the fall 2002, 638 high school students were taking dual credit classes through WKCTC. This fall, the number increased to 1,113.

Recent studies have shown that while 70% of high school graduates enroll in college right after high school, 30% don't make it to the sophomore year and less than 50% persist to graduation. Educators nationwide have advocated concurrent or dual enrollment as a powerful way to change those statistics.

Reilly said he has certainly seen the benefit of being allowed to take college classes while he was still in high school. "I honestly don't think I would have gotten into the college I got into if I hadn't gone to PCC, and I know for sure I wouldn't have been prepared," he said. After his first college class, Reilly decided he really needed to take more classes to prepare for college. During his senior year of high school, he enrolled as a PCC student while still participating in extracurricular activities at his high school.

"The other students didn't really look at me and say, 'what's a seventeen year old doing in our college?' They welcomed me in and were friendly," he said.

Reilly, 25, credits the head start he got at the community college with preparing him for what he faced when he arrived at Bucknell University in Lewisburg, Pennsylvania. He especially praised faculty members Berry Craig, David Nickell and Tracey Jordan for their support and dedication.

"I wrote more at PCC than I did in the prior 3 years I had at high school, and I had some professors that really tore my papers apart and really made me a better writer," Reilly said. "That helped when I got to Bucknell."

Reilly graduated in 2002 from Bucknell with a Bachelor of Science degree in Business Administration.

Now living in New Jersey, he recently interned with an advertising agency in Philadelphia, and was accepted this month into the Adcenter at Virginia Commonwealth University. The Adcenter is a two-year graduate program providing an intensive, real-

world education for future advertising leaders. It offers a master's degree in communications with concentrations in art direction, copywriting, account planning, account management and media planning.

Reilly said he'll never forget his community college experience.

"If it were not for my time at PCC, I'm convinced I would have had a very difficult time adjusting to the high academic standards of Bucknell," Reilly said. "The community college really gave me a big bang for my buck."



Officers of the local chapter of Phi Theta Kappa recently conducted a welcome and an orientation for new members.

The national honor society is the largest and most prestigious honor society in the world. Students must have completed at least 12 hours of coursework and have a grade point average of 3.5 or higher in order to be a member. Membership is available to all degree seeking students in the college.

Dean Sherry Anderson congratulated the students on their academic and personal success. She told the students that PTK would help them accomplish their goals and dreams.

The next PTK meeting is March 26 in Rosenthal Hall Room 207.

